



The Jar of Ocean Jewels - Hope Edition

By Michael Mendez



The morning was misty and grey, and Kai felt like the fog had settled inside him. He felt a "Deep Blue" weighing on his heart—a heavy, quiet feeling that made the world seem much too big and his own feet much too small. Soren walked beside him, his boots clicking softly on the damp stones. "Hope is like the morning mist, Kai," Soren said gently. "It hides the path for a while, but it doesn't mean the path has vanished."



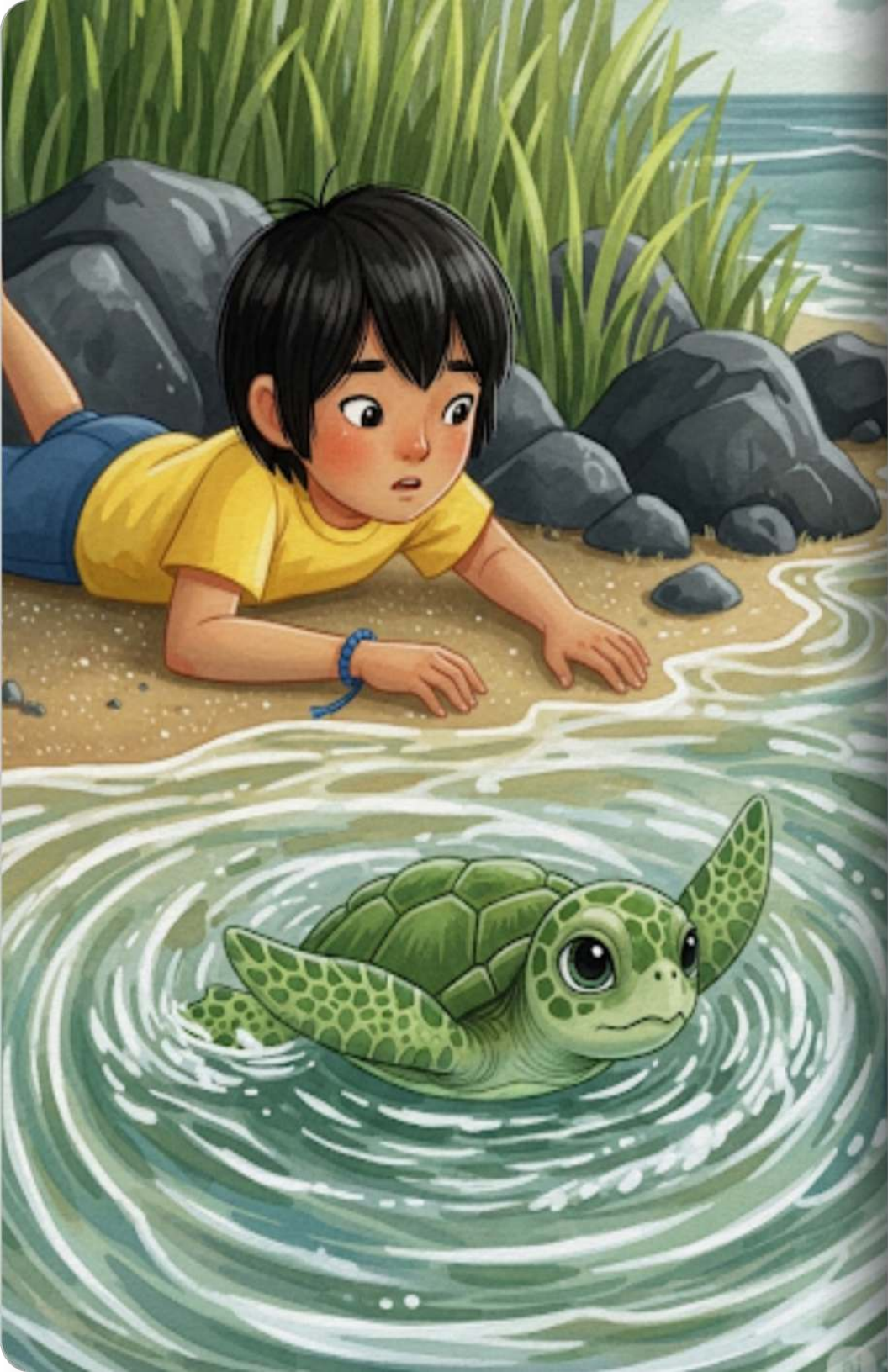
The "Deep Blue" made Kai feel like he was drifting far from the shore. He looked out at the ocean, but the horizon was hidden by a thick, milky wall of clouds. He felt stuck, like a boat anchored in the mud while the tide stayed out. He wondered if the sun would ever feel warm on his face again, or if the grey was here to stay.



Soren sat down on the cool sand and patted the space next to him. He didn't try to pull the clouds away or tell the sun to hurry up. "When the fog is thick, we forget that the lighthouse is still standing," Soren said, pointing toward the place where the light usually shone. "Hope isn't about seeing the end of the journey, Kai. It's about believing the shore is still there, even when you can't see your toes."



Soren reached into his pocket and pulled out the glass jar, its contents rattling like tiny chimes. He tilted it until a piece of glass the color of a lemon drop caught the dull light. "This is 'Solaris Glass,'" Soren explained. "It was once a broken bottle, lost in the deep, dark trenches. But it kept rolling, kept moving, until it found the light again. It never gave up on the surface."



Near a cluster of swaying sea grass, they spotted a tiny green sea turtle named Malia. She was very small, and a strong current was pushing her backward toward the rocks. Her little flippers worked hard, paddling against the heavy water. Kai watched her struggle and felt a pang in his chest. He knew what it was like to feel like the tide was just too strong to swim against.



Malia didn't stop. She took a tiny breath and tucked her head down, pushing with all her might. Suddenly, a gentle wave caught her and lifted her over the rocks, depositing her into a calm, clear pool filled with sunlight. She rested there, her shell gleaming, having reached the quiet water she was looking for. She hadn't known the pool was there, but she had kept swimming anyway.



Soren put a hand on Kai's shoulder. "Malia didn't have a map, Kai. She just had the feeling that if she kept moving, things would change. That is what hope is—the tiny 'keep going' that lives in your flippers. It's the whisper that tells you the current will eventually turn in your favor." Kai took a long breath, and the "Deep Blue" in his chest felt a little lighter, like a bubble rising to the top.



As the mist began to swirl and lift, Kai saw a flash of gold tucked inside a discarded seashell. He reached down and pulled out a piece of sea glass that looked like a drop of pure sunshine. It was smooth and warm in his palm. He realized that hope wasn't a giant sun; it was this small, bright thing he could hold onto when the world turned grey.

The wind picked up, chasing the last of the fog away. The horizon appeared again, a sharp blue line where the sea met the sky. Kai walked back with Soren, the jar tucked under his arm. He knew that some days would be misty and some currents would be strong, but he had his golden jewel. He knew that as long as he kept paddling, the "Deep Blue" would always turn back into the morning gold.